An argument against allosemy from R-nominals

non-compositionality requires non-terminal interpretation

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Takeaways

- The complex-head approach to nominalizations (which relies on allosemy) under- and over-generates R(eferring)-readings
- This weakens the complex-head story for nominalization ambiguity
- We need to refer to ≥ 3 elements to account for R-readings of nominalizations

1. Recap: nominalization ambiguity

(1) The local radio channel's *transmission* of the morning's headlines was interrupted by the breaking news. *(event=AS)*

(2) Most *transmissions* in modern cars use the synchromesh design. *(thing=R)*

AS-nominals:
- affixation to an attested verb (= $transmit_V$)
- meaning is related to the meaning of the verb, i.e. compositional (in a non-technical sense) (= *ACT OF TRANSMITTING*)
- occur with the same nominals around it (= arguments?) as the corresponding verb

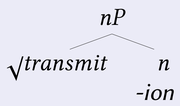
R-nominals:
- need not involve affixation to an attested verb (*vis-ion*)
- meaning may be unrelated to the attested verb's, or unpredictable; i.e., non-compositional (= *GEARBOX*)

- What is this ambiguity, and what are R-nominals?

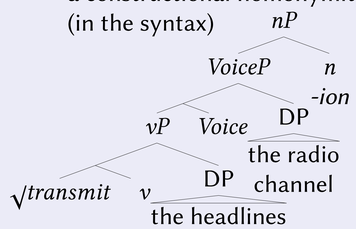
2. Phrasal vs. complex-head approaches

- R-nominals lack verbal properties because essentially they're (3): either in syntax (phrasal accounts) or LF (complex-head accounts)

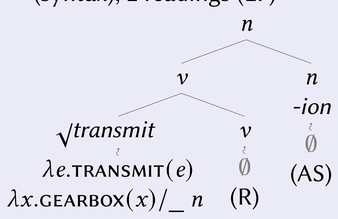
(3)



(4) Phrasal layering: a constructional homonymity! (in the syntax)



(5) **Complex-head**: 1 structure (syntax), 2 readings (LF):



- A complex-head account relies on allosemy:

  Allosemy: one syntactic terminal can map to multiple semantic values (*allosemes*).

- Intervening *v* is 'null', and *n* and √*root* are suddenly local. **All R-readings have a null *v* alloseme**
- The 'non-compositional' (R) meaning results from an interaction of **exactly 2** elements: the root and the nominalizer

3. Crucial assumptions of allosemy

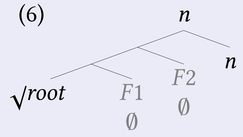
(i) Only terminals are interpreted.
(ii) The interpretation of the root can be determined by its local context.
(iii) Some nodes do not participate in locality considerations.

4. Predictions

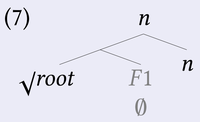
Suppose several verbal elements occur in a nominalization.

Allosemy prediction: All three structures have an R-reading, and the same R-reading.

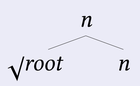
(6)



(7)



(8)



1. If √*root*-*F*1-*F*2-*n* has an R-reading, then an R-reading is predicted everywhere:
   If √*root*-*F*1-*F*2-*n* has an R-reading, then *F*1 and *F*2 have a ∅ interpretation.
   The interpretation of functional items is chosen freely in a structure.
   → *F*1 can be ∅ in any structure, including √*root*-*F*1-*n*, producing an R-reading
2. The same R-reading is predicted everywhere:
   If √*root*-*F*1-*F*2-*n* has an R-reading, then *F*1 and *F*2 can have a ∅ interpretation.
   If √*root*-*F*1-*n* has an R-reading, then *F*1 has a ∅ interpretation in this structure.
   → (6)-(8) all have the same R-reading.

5. Lithuanian exhibits the three structures

- Lithuanian nominalizations retain the **perfective prefix** and the **reflexive** morpheme
- These nominalizations can have R-readings

(9) a. **su-si**-tar-ti
PFV-REFL-say-INF
'to agree (on something)'

b. **su-si**-tar-im-as
PFV-REFL-say-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'agreeing' (AS);
'a contract, an agreement' (R)

(10) a. **pa-si**-mat-y-ti
PFV-REFL-see-TH-INF
'to see each other, to meet'; *'to date'

b. **pa-si**-mat-ym-as
PFV-REFL-see-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'(their) meeting of each other' (AS);
'a date' (R)

- Impossible in a phrasal account
- Natural in a complex-head account

6. Distinct R-readings in the three structures

- The triplet in (11) shows three nominalizations, all based on the same root
- They get distinct R-interpretations, depending on presence of PFV and REFL

(11) a. **nu-si**-stat-ym-as
PFV-REFL-stand-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
R: **'a bias, a conviction, a (negative) attitude or opinion'**
*'a setting', *'a bet'

b. **nu**-stat-ym-as
PFV-stand-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
R: **'a setting'**
*'a bias', *'a bet'

c. stat-ym-as
stand-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
R: **'a bet'**
*'a bias', *'a setting'

- Allosemy undergenerates and overgenerates

7. No R-reading in a subset of structures

- Nominals with PFV and REFL can have an R-reading
- Take away either PFV or REFL, and the R reading disappears

(12) a. **pa-si**-mat-ym-as
PFV-REFL-see-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'their meeting of each other' (AS);
'a date' (R)

b. **pa**-mat-ym-as
PFV-see-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'the seeing' (AS);
*'a date' (R)

(13) a. **su-si**-tar-im-as
PFV-REFL-say-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'agreeing' (AS);
'a contract, an agreement' (R)

b. **su**-tar-im-as
PFV-say-NMLZ-M.SG.NOM
'agreeing' (AS);
*'a contract' (R)

- Both PFV and REFL are crucial for the emergence of a particular R-reading. The R-reading is not determined by the root(verb)-meaning and *n*
- Difference even in (13), where the respective verbs both mean 'to agree' and even have near-identical argument structure properties
- Only a particular combination of structural items results in a particular R-reading
- Allosemy overgenerates

Conclusions

This argument weakens the complex-head story for nominalization ambiguity:

- We need to be able to take ≥ 3 things into account to know what an R-nominal means
- Insofar as R-nominals have non-compositional meaning, we need an encoding of non-compositionality that refers to >2 terminals
- Complex-heads + allosemy makes incorrect predictions for R-nominals in Lithuanian
- If nominalizations really have a single structure, and R-readings rely on 'semantically invisible' terminals, then we cannot generate the full array of R-readings, and instead generate the incorrect ones for a variety of structures
- Intermediate structure between the root and the nominalizer must be taken into account for LF interpretation
- In the complex head account, constructional homonymity of nominalizations is abound – the very thing it set out to get rid of

Selected references

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